

(8.17—8.23)

**【8.17| The Guardian】‘Shanghai turns into the sea’ as
Typhoon Dolphin inundates China’s east coast**

【Para.1】

Torrential rain and storms in Typhoon Dolphin’s wake have inundated China’s eastern coastal region and flooded streets in Shanghai, where about 40% of flights were grounded yesterday due to the weather.

【Para.2】

Dolphin packed maximum sustained winds of 94mph near its centre when it made landfall in Zhejiang, south of Shanghai, on Sunday before weakening to a tropical storm.

【Para.3】

More than 1.2million people across Fujian province and the cities of Wenzhou and Shanghai were moved to safety as the typhoon approached.

【Para.4】

Many streets in Shanghai, the country's second most populous city, were flooded, including in the main commercial centres.

【Para.5】

The city's two airports cancelled 943 flights as a result of the typhoon, the state broadcaster CCTV said.

【Para.6】

A weather station in central Shanghai yesterday recorded nearly 313mm (12in) of rain in the 24 hours to 7am local time, its highest 24-hour rainfall in more than 150 years of records. Another station in the city recorded nearly 400mm.

【Para.7】

The hashtag "Shanghai turns into the sea" began trending on the Chinese social media platform Weibo as videos circulated showing flooded streets around Wukang Mansion, one of the city's best-known landmarks.

【Para.8】

“It rained almost all night last night. When I woke up this morning, I found the neighbourhood flooded,” said 39-year-old Hou Lina, who works in sales in Jiading in Shanghai.

【Para.9】

“I’ve lived in Shanghai for 10 years, and this is the first time I’ve experienced such inconvenience from a typhoon. This is the first time I’ve encountered such widespread flooding,” she said.

【Para.10】

In Shanghai’s Jinshan, the district authority said non-essential businesses and organisations could temporarily halt operations, classes, outdoor events and transit services, amid forecasts of continued strong winds and heavy rain.

【Para.11】

Authorities warned that 74 rivers in the Taihu Lake basin and the coastal areas of eastern Zhejiang had exceeded warning levels, and that flood risks for small and medium-sized rivers in heavy rainfall areas were high.

【Para.12】

The strongest typhoon to hit China this year, Dolphin is forecast to move inland to the central provinces of Hubei and Henan in the coming days, while also pushing moisture north.

【Para.13】

Authorities in Beijing warned of torrential rain and said the capital was prepared to activate its flood control response this morning.

【Para.14】

Beijing was expected to experience “significant rainfall” from today until Thursday, with authorities warning of flash floods in the city and landslides in surrounding mountains.

【Para.15】

The typhoon travelled 6,000km (3,728 miles) before making landfall, giving it a life cycle three times longer than a typical typhoon, and bringing an ultra-large cloud system that enveloped China’s east, CCTV said.

【Para.16】

Dolphin's impact was being compared with 2023's Typhoon Doksuri, which crossed the country after causing destruction in south-eastern Fujian province, unleashing record rainfall on Beijing.

【Para.17】

CCTV said Beijing, Tianjin and Hebei would need to brace for heavy rain into Thursday as the storm clouds met colder air in the north.

【Para.18】

On China's southern coast, Hong Kong reached 36.9C on Sunday, which the Hong Kong Observatory said marked its hottest day since records began in 1884.

【Para.19】

The forecaster Tropical Storm Risk said it expected the 2026 north-west Pacific typhoon season to be one of the most active on record and to include 28 tropical storms, 20 typhoons and 13 intense typhoons.

【Para.20】

It said the continuing strong El Niño event, high activity to date and weaker-than-usual trade winds across the north-west Pacific basin were key reasons for the intensity of the typhoon season.

11 August 2026 | The Guardian

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【8.18| The Guardian】Pet detectives: dogs can tell fearful from angry or sad human faces, research finds

【Para.1】

While humans keep a close eye on their pets, it seems our pets are keeping a close eye on us too, as a study has revealed dog brains can distinguish between different types of unhappy human expressions.

【Para.2】

Dogs whose brain activity was monitored not only distinguished happy faces from other expressions, but could tell fearful faces apart from those that are angry or sad, researchers found.

【Para.3】

Dr Laura Cuaya said: “This is the first demonstration that the dog brain can distinguish between emotions from the same valence [positive or negative character],” she said.

【Para.4】

Writing in the journal iScience, Cuaya and colleagues from the University of Vienna described working with pet dogs that had been trained to lie still, awake and unrestrained, within an MRI scanner.

【Para.5】

In the first experiment, eight dogs were shown five sets of happy faces and five sets of neutral faces. Each set contained four photos of humans that were unfamiliar to the dog but were of the same gender as their primary caregiver. This was repeated five times for each dog.

【Para.6】

The results revealed increased activity in certain parts of the brain when the dogs were shown happy faces compared with neutral ones. Cuaya said these areas were associated with higher visual processing, social processing and reward processing – suggesting the dog was experiencing something positive.

【Para.7】

Dr Raúl Hernández Pérez, the first author of the study, said the results raised another question, however: “We don’t know if these regions are related just to happy faces or to emotional faces in general.”

【Para.8】

The team then carried out a second MRI experiment involving 12 dogs. Each was shown new sets of unfamiliar male and female human faces, this time bearing four different expressions: happiness, sadness, fear and anger.

【Para.9】

The researchers used machine learning to analyse activity in the same brain regions identified in the first experiment, revealing that the animals could distinguish happy faces from each negative expression – but could not distinguish between different types of unhappy face.

【Para.10】

However, when activity across the whole dog brain was analysed, the researchers found it was possible to distinguish between sad v fearful faces, and angry v fearful faces – but not between angry and sad faces.

【Para.11】

Hernández said different negative expressions may trigger different responses in dogs as they represented different types of threat.

【Para.12】

Cuaya said previous behavioural studies had shown dogs can tell apart some human facial expressions, but that they tended to only test two at a time, one positive and one negative.

【Para.13】

The authors said it might be harder for dogs to tell apart two human facial expressions if they were both negative or both positive, and dogs might also need additional information – such as body language – to distinguish anger from sadness.

【Para.14】

The research has limitations, including its small sample size; the fact that most of the dogs were border collies, and all were healthy and without behavioural problems.

【Para.15】

Cuaya said the study could have practical implications: for example, expressing happiness when training a dog could aid the learning process.

【Para.16】

Bridget Waller, a professor of evolution and social behaviour at Nottingham Trent University, who was not involved in the study, described the work as fascinating, saying it showed how “dogs have been shaped through domestication to understand human behaviour”.

【Para.17】

“Smiling is the most commonly used human facial expression, vital to our social interactions, and so it makes sense that dogs have developed a particular ability to distinguish this from other facial movements,” she said. “It seems less clear that they can distinguish between the other expressions, and this would make sense as these are less commonly produced in human social interaction.”

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【8.19| The Guardian】Paying the price for not investing in our youth

【Para.1】

Most people think Britain is not working as it should. For young people, the situation is at its most acute: only one in four believe that everyone in society has a fair crack. Most think the game is rigged.

【Para.2】

It is clear why the generation who grew up in the post-2008 crash austerity years as well as Covid are downbeat: the level of public service provision their parents enjoyed is gone, living costs are rising, the AI revolution is changing everything, and the planet is on fire.

【Para.3】

That is why Alan Milburn's review into youth unemployment is vital. Britain missing out on the talents of 1 million young people not in education, employment or training (Neet) is a problem that extends beyond the jobs market. It is about how the building blocks of a just and prosperous economy have been whittled away, and is a call to action to put things right.

【Para.4】

As with so many of the country's problems right now, some of the big drivers of youth inactivity stem from the austerity years. That is not to say that other contributing factors – not least Labour's management of the economy, AI upending youth jobs, and the cost of living crisis – are not playing a role. But there is mounting evidence the consequences of the Tory spending cuts are maturing with disastrous consequences.

【Para.5】

Milburn says the risk of a child becoming Neet can be traced to their earliest years in preschool. To look back, therefore, at the past 16 years of change in education policy, youth services and the public sector more broadly – the lifespan of the generation just entering the workforce – is instructive.

【Para.6】

Across the board, funding has been cut. Within youth services in England, spending is down by 76%, a loss of £1.3bn. Thousands of youth clubs have been closed and social workers lost. The per-pupil level of spending for schools in England was frozen for 14 years. Investment in school buildings, many of which have been affected by the Raac – or crumbling concrete – crisis, also collapsed by a quarter.

【Para.7】

The situation is stark in the Neet crisis. For every £1 the state spends on employment support for young people, it shells out £25 on benefits. With the rise in inactivity for a generation cut adrift, the cost is only going to climb without intervention.

【Para.8】

It is a pattern repeated across government. Rather than investing in public services early to stop problems from developing, the state is in firefighting mode. For Andy Burnham, the task will be to end this shortsighted approach by rebuilding what the thinktank Demos calls a preventive state – a model involving investment to support the foundations of society. The size of the economic, fiscal and social prize would be substantial.

【Para.9】

The challenge for ministers is that the cost to the economy and to government finances of the Neet crisis is £125bn a year and rising. Getting more young people into work would, though, revitalise the life

chances of millions and drive up labour participation – boosting the economy and public finances.

【Para.10】

Before the autumn budget, there is a compelling argument for Burnham's government to take action. However, building a preventive state will come with challenges for a prime minister hemmed in by the UK's current tight fiscal predicament, and who is in a hurry to show progress.

【Para.11】

Moving money upstream is difficult because the savings from preventive spending take time to materialise, and spending on acute need and welfare cannot be simply turned off. Nowhere is this clearer than early-years services, where changes can take a lifetime to show up in the numbers.

【Para.12】

That timing problem is why the Treasury has often been sceptical. The costs appear immediately, while the savings arrive years later – often

benefiting a different government. The incentives favour firefighting over fixing.

【Para.13】

However, refusing to make the transition is a bad choice. Britain is already paying the price of a crumbling NHS, rising welfare bill, jobs market inactivity, and consequent weak economic growth.

【Para.14】

Milburn's review is therefore a critical test of whether Britain will grasp the nettle to rebuild a preventive state from the ashes of the austerity years. The alternative is to settle for a country hamstrung by the costs of failure, where young people feel lost.

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【8.20| Economist】Screening for success

In praise of designer-ish babies

【Para.1】

Having transformed human life, Silicon Valley is now coming for birth. A spate of startups offer screening services that allow couples having children via in-vitro fertilisation (IVF) to assess embryos based on their genetic risk of diseases such as breast cancer and diabetes. Some venture further into science-fiction territory, providing scores for IQ and height, or even eye and hair colour.

【Para.2】

Critics are dismayed. Some worry firms are pushing immature technology onto vulnerable couples. Others say that even if the tech works, its use is immoral. Both arguments contain kernels of truth; neither is ultimately convincing. Banning or heavily restricting embryo

screening would be a mistake.

【Para.3】

For now, the debate is a niche concern. The startups mostly cater to the rich, famous and odd. Yet that will change. A wave of investment means that the cost of IVF is likely to fall. If offered embryo screening at the same time, many couples will take it. One survey suggests that three-quarters of Americans support screening embryos for diseases; about a third say the same for non-disease traits. And that is before competitive pressure kicks in. Who wants to see their child bested by genetically selected classmates?

【Para.4】

Many medics—including nearly every genetics and reproductive-medicine group in the rich world—question whether such “polygenic” prediction is ready for consumers. In Britain, where fertility is more regulated than in America, selecting an embryo on the basis of non-approved factors is unlawful.

【Para.5】

There are indeed reasons for caution. Polygenic scores are tricky. For many diseases caused by a single gene, testing offers near-certainty:

if an embryo has the material, it will develop the condition. Yet an assessment of multiple genes leads to risk estimates, rather than a binary answer—and such estimates are more accurate for people with European ancestry, because they are better represented in genetic databases.

【Para.6】

Further caveats are in order. Risk reductions can look large in relative terms but be small in absolute ones, particularly for rare diseases. Selecting for some traits may raise the risk of other less desirable ones. Even for highly genetically determined traits like height, parents remain limited by the range found in their own embryos.

【Para.7】

These facts are an argument for disclosure, however, rather than legal restrictions or outright bans. If companies want to offer polygenic scoring, they must adequately communicate the technology's limits and risks. They should also let their tests undergo independent scrutiny. This will not scupper a nascent business, since the startups are not, as some critics allege, selling snake oil. A study in 2019 found that parents choosing from among ten embryos may be able to boost their child's height by 1-6cm and IQ by between one and seven points—with tech that is now nearly a decade old. As genetic databases get better and cover

broader populations, and AI draws out the relationship between genes and traits, scores will improve.

【Para.8】

Such progress will raise difficult ethical questions. Some, including the “Make America Healthy Again” movement, argue that fertility tech corrupts what should be a natural process. Others worry that if polygenic screening is limited to the rich, their offspring will have another unfair advantage. The scariest critique is that fertility entrepreneurs are this century’s eugenicists.

【Para.9】

But none of these arguments stands up to scrutiny. “Unnatural” technology is already used in many modern births: this argument against embryo selection just as easily applies to IVF, for instance, which only zealots want banned. Costs should come down, making screening more widely available. And there is a big difference between the murderous coercion of early-20th-century eugenics programmes and parents seeking as much knowledge as possible when picking an embryo.

【Para.10】

Couples desperate for a clever child might be better advised to focus

on what happens after birth. Yet so long as parents understand there is no such thing as the perfect baby, the state should not stand in the way of a bit more information.

August 15TH- 21ST | Leaders

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【8.21| Economist】Opening time

The world's biggest fast-food chain is moving into pubs

【Para.1】

Even in the most remote corner of China a frothy Fulujia beer is waiting for you. The company, whose name translates as “Lucky Deer”, has opened more than 3,200 mini-pubs across the country since 2021, making it the world's largest bar chain. More impressive than its scale are

its prices. A pint is poured for as little as 5.9 yuan (\$0.87), whether it is served in a big city or a border town.

【Para.2】

Fulujia premises are small but uniform micro-watering holes that have 20 beers on draft and a bijou seating area. They often sell bar snacks such as fried pork and edamame beans. When asked why prices are so low, the proprietor of a recently opened Fulujia in Lushui, a town in the deep south-west, says it is because the company is owned by Mixue Bingcheng, a tea and cold-drinks mega-chain that has around 60,000 outlets worldwide. Last year it overtook McDonald's, the American burger giant, to become the world's largest fast-food operator by number of locations.

【Para.3】

Mixue bought a controlling stake in Fulujia in October. Both are run on similar franchise models. Franchisees pay an upfront cost of about 60,000 yuan for everything that is needed to launch a mini-pub, such as beer pumps and branded decorations (though rent and renovation costs are not included). They are exempt from paying royalties for three years.

【Para.4】

The secret to Mixue's success is its mastery of supply chains. It is often described as a logistics company rather than a fast-food chain. The efficiency with which Mixue has been able to move supplies has kept costs for consumers remarkably low—its marquee drink is a four-yuan lemonade. Fulujia uses the same logistics networks to ship its beer from Henan province, where both Mixue and Fulujia are based, to its franchisees, who do not pay transport costs, even when they are as far away as Lushui, more than 2,000km from the brewery.

【Para.5】

A franchising model coupled with a highly efficient supply chain has turbocharged the openings of Mixue outlets—roughly 40 a day appeared in 2025. The effects have been similar for Fulujia. Nearly two-thirds of its 3,200 bars have been launched since Mixue bought its stake late last year. This also appears to be working for the group's café chain, Lucky Cup, of which there were at least 10,000 in China at the end of last year.

【Para.6】

The model is enjoying some success outside China, too. Mixue has around 5,000 outlets abroad, making it by far the most successful Chinese fast-food chain outside the country. It has also opened Lucky Cup branches in Malaysia and Thailand. Fulujia has not yet announced plans

to go overseas. But with pubs in New York and London serving up painfully expensive pints, cheap Chinese brews would be sure to receive a welcome from drinkers.

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【8.22| Economist】Under a cloud

South-East Asia braces for more smoke from Indonesia

【Para.1】

In 2015, as South-East Asia was engulfed in toxic smog caused by fires in Indonesia, Jusuf Kalla, the country's vice-president at the time, suggested that his neighbours needed a change in perspective. "For 11 months they enjoyed nice air from Indonesia and they never thanked us,"

he said. South-East Asians flocked to a satirical website created to express gratitude to Indonesia. The site has registered more than 34m votes of sarcastic thanks.

【Para.2】

That number may soon grow. Fears of another severe haze are rising as fires rage in Indonesia. Weather-watchers estimate that the number of blazes detected across the island of Borneo in the first 12 days of August alone exceeds the figure registered during the entire month in each of the past seven years. The smoke is already forcing officials to act. In Pontianak, the capital of the Indonesian province of West Kalimantan, schools have shut. In neighbouring Sarawak, in Malaysia, officials urged people to stay indoors. Singapore has put its own responders on standby.

【Para.3】

Meteorologists fear that much worse is to come. El Niño, a weather pattern associated with unusually warm waters in the Pacific, tends to cause drier conditions in the region. This increases the chance of fires, especially on Indonesia's peatlands, where the carbon-rich soil is more combustible and where fires smouldering underground are hard to extinguish. Many climatologists think that this year's El Niño will turn out to be the strongest yet, raising concerns about a haze episode

comparable to the one in 2015.

【Para.4】

That would be a disaster. The smog in 2015 caused some 100,000 excess deaths in Indonesia, Malaysia and Singapore, according to one study. But there was also a heavy economic toll: the World Bank put Indonesia's losses at \$16.1bn, almost 2% of GDP. Economies in the region are already vulnerable, having been hit to varying degrees by the war in Iran.

【Para.5】

That war could also contribute to the haze. The blockade of the Strait of Hormuz has pushed up fuel and fertiliser costs, prompting the Indonesian government to mandate greater use of biofuels. This, in turn, is driving up the demand for palm oil, putting pressure on farmers and plantation companies to clear more land with fire.

【Para.6】

The region may be better prepared than it was a decade ago. Better satellite monitoring has improved forecasts. A centre in Singapore tracks fires and smoke across the region and provides early warnings, allowing governments to implement public-health measures. In April ASEAN, the

regional bloc, inaugurated the secretariat of a new haze-control centre in Jakarta, Indonesia's capital, which seeks to improve co-ordination between governments.

【Para.7】

But for all the machinery of regional co-operation, it still lacks much bite. ASEAN has had an agreement on transboundary haze since 2002, but implementation and enforcement rest with national governments. Its fund to pay for anti-haze resources, such as water-bombing aircraft and other firefighting equipment, relies on voluntary contributions and remains small.

【Para.8】

Ultimately, the severity of haze-related problems this year will depend on what happens in Indonesia. After the disaster of 2015, Joko Widodo, then the president, made prevention a priority. His successor, Prabowo Subianto, has kept much of that emphasis. Last year he created a new department to tackle blazes, and strengthened patrols, aerial surveillance and emergency teams. In the coming weeks, they face trial by fire.

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【8.23| Economist】Well Informed

Can you hack your gut microbiome?

【Para.1】

The trillions of bugs in a human gut digest complex carbohydrates into fatty acids that provide about 10% of an individual's calories. They synthesise vitamins, notably K (which regulates blood clotting) and various members of the B group. They help tune the immune system. They suppress the growth of pathogens. And they regulate production of signalling molecules, such as serotonin, involved in sending messages from the gut to the brain.

【Para.2】

Keeping your gut microbiome in tip-top condition is thus wise. Maintaining a diverse mix of bacteria in it is widely thought a good way to do this. And, since different species have different appetites, diversity of diet makes sense.

【Para.3】

In 2018 an American citizen-science project showed that people eating 30 types of plants a week had significantly more diverse microbiomes than those eating fewer than ten. And work from Stanford University, published in 2021, confirmed that fermented foods such as kimchi and sauerkraut diversify microbiomes, too. Some people, though, feel such off-the-peg advice is insufficient. They would prefer something bespoke.

【Para.4】

For a suitable fistful of dollars, they can have it. So-called direct-to-consumer (D2C) firms will analyse stool samples and compile lists of the bugs therein, based on the DNA and RNA they find. Such firms may also offer tailored dietary recommendations, doses of live bacteria and special bug-friendly supplements, all intended to fill any microbial blanks that their tests have flagged up.

【Para.5】

The problem with this approach is that there is no “right” microbiome to act as a reference. In fact, microbiomes can differ quite a bit from each other while still being perfectly effective at delivering a desirable outcome to their host. The biggest red flag for poor gut health is a simple lack of biodiversity—which is what a varied and partly fermented diet is good at correcting. By contrast, the idea that tinkering with the presence or absence of this or that type of bug will perceptibly improve your health has scant published scientific basis, and many D2C firms are reluctant to share the details of proprietary data on which they base their claims.

【Para.6】

There are exceptions. In Britain, Tim Spector has ridden the twin horses of academic science (a post at King’s College, London) and commerce (he helped found a D2C firm called Zoe) without so far falling off. Results from Zoe’s customers are fed, with their permission, into respectable, peer-reviewed research. So far, this suggests individually tailored diets do not have huge effects, but may help at the margins.

【Para.7】

However, even if a bespoke approach does have value, it must surely

depend on the microbial censuses carried out by D2C firms being accurate. To test that, researchers at America's National Institute of Standards and Technology prepared 21 sets of homogenised (and thus identical) faeces and sent three to each of seven D2C firms. When the results (which were published in February) came back there were notable differences not only between different firms' analyses but also, in one case, between those of an individual company.

【Para.8】

As Jonathan Eisen, an evolutionary microbiologist at the University of California, Davis, observes, just because microbiomes differ does not mean an era of personalised microbiome medicine is coming any time soon. In fact, he puts it more strongly than this, saying, "Most of the claims [in this area] are bogus." Perhaps better to save your money and invest in a jar of kimchi.

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